

SCAMS • CHAPTER 4

Pressure tactics, both ways

LAST CHECKED 3 NOVEMBER 2026 • 7 MINUTES TO READ

Pressure is any move that makes saying no feel costly. This chapter names those moves from the side of the person who has to spot and refuse them, whether they come from a dom, a sub or a design.

EVIDENCE ◆ Verified ◆ Reported ◆ Vivian's field notes

This chapter is not advice for your situation.

IN 30 SECONDS

01 Pressure takes away time, choice or privacy. The moves are few and they repeat.

02 Some of these moves are play between adults who chose them. The line is whether you chose, with a limit and a stop you control.

03 Words about respect don’t mean the pressure has stopped.

04 Pressure also lives in games and apps, with no person behind it.

05 It runs both ways, but not equally: the dom gets paid and designs the tools.

YOU WILL LEARN

- ✓ How to spot the moves that take away your time, your feelings or your privacy.
- ✓ A short counter for each move.
- ✓ Which designs in games and apps are pressure.
- ✓ What subs do to doms, and how written rules answer it.
- ✓ How to refuse once, calmly, and where to go when the spending stops being a game.

> *Pressure is the part of this game that works best, and it works on anyone.*
>
> — VIVIAN

PART 01

How pressure works

Pressure takes away time, choice or privacy. Nearly every move below does one of the three, and it works best on someone who’s aroused, tired, ashamed or attached. This scene runs on those states, so here they feel normal, and that’s why the same moves work so well. ◆

Press gives real examples. A former participant describes men who sold cars, took on debt and worked second jobs. ◆ The same reporting says some dominants blackmailed submissives or targeted people in support groups. ◆ A writer calls the threat of exposure a common punishment from financial doms. ◆ A study notes that some findommes keep humiliation lists of clients who fail to give enough tribute. ◆

V

VIVIAN'S FIELD NOTES

Humiliation, ownership and rigged bets can be fantasies adults choose. The same words become pressure when the sub didn't choose them, can't see the cost or has no way to stop. The test I use: is the performance steering the spending? A sub who gave in was up against pressure built to work, and nothing here is a verdict on him.

◆

PART 02

The moves, and the counter

Each row says what you may see or hear, then what to do. Some moves are described and some are written in typical words. None is quoted from anyone.

Time and choice

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

01 *A deadline of tonight, after which the offer is gone*

THE COUNTER

Wait an hour, then a day. Never send under a time limit. Real play survives the wait. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

02 *A two-choice ultimatum with a same-day deadline, where both choices suit the dom*

THE COUNTER

Don't accept the two choices. There's always a third answer: reply tomorrow. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

03 *"You already owe me a round sum."*

THE COUNTER

There's no debt unless you agreed to one in advance. You can walk away. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

04 *"Your limit was cute. Now prove it."*

THE COUNTER

The limit is the rule. Say it once, then stop discussing it. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

05 *Respect for your limits, followed right away by a request just past them*

THE COUNTER

Take the respect and ignore the next sentence. Words about limits don't mean the nudge has stopped. ◆

Time pressure is most dangerous when several doms push it at once on a sub who's chatting with all of them. In my experience that's how a single evening can empty a month.

Feelings

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

01 *Constant praise and attention, then sudden silence (love bombing)*

THE COUNTER

Notice the pattern. Never pay to end a silence. Ask what's wanted and slow down.

◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

02 *Anger, then disappointment, then forgiveness with conditions: "After everything I've done for you."*

THE COUNTER

Feelings aren't a bill. A healthy bond survives a boundary. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

03 *Permission given along with visible hurt*

THE COUNTER

Permission that comes with hurt isn't free. Ask for a plain yes or no, and talk about the need underneath. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

04 *An offer of support, then coldness when you say you're fine*

THE COUNTER

Warmth that depends on doing as you're told teaches you that independence costs affection. Keep the warmth that doesn't. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

05 *A show of how easily you could be controlled, then a promise not to use that power*

THE COUNTER

The power is there whether or not it's used. Notice it. ◆

Keys, isolation and money timing

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

01 *A demand for your login, a code or a remote session as proof of honesty*

THE COUNTER

Keys to your identity prove nothing about honesty. Refuse, and offer nothing from your accounts. See Case files. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

02 *Questions that treat your wish for privacy as suspicious*

THE COUNTER

Say the boundary once, calmly. Wanting privacy needs no proof. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

03 *Requests to bring your doubts to one dom only, to ask her before you contact another dom, or to tell others you're busy*

THE COUNTER

This cuts you off from outside views. Keep your outside relationships. A consensual version can be renegotiated and asks no proof of private acts. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

04 *"How much did you earn this month?", or a bigger ask timed to your payday or balance*

THE COUNTER

Never share your income, payday or balance. Keep your monthly limit separate from what's in the account. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

05 *Lukewarm thanks for a send, with a hint that you can obviously afford more*

THE COUNTER

That's a sales line. It tells you nothing about what you can afford. Set the amount before the evening. ◆

Say no once, plainly. I'd rather lose a send than keep a sub who can't refuse me.

VIVIAN ◆

PART 03

Pressure built into games and apps

Some pressure needs no person. A tool or a game can do it with a price, a timer or a streak. The table puts the pressure version of each design next to a safer one. Each row is a pattern seen in spending tools. ◆

Same feature, two designs

	Pressure version	Safer version
Price	Hidden behind a multiplier, so the real total swings a lot	A flat price, shown before the charge
Stop	Closing the window is the only way to stop, or the page locks until you pay	A stop that works in every state, for free
Odds	Near-misses, bets only the house can win, ties that go to the house	Odds shown, and a real prize for winning
Rewards	Streaks, a free daily spin, cards that fade unless you pull again	Rewards that don't punish a day away
Total	Not shown, or hidden behind an overlay	A running total, always visible
Limit	None, or typed in the middle of a session	Set before you start, and enforced so you can't raise it mid-session

If a payment system can't be explained in one sentence, don't play it. A rule that sounds like a small tweak can carry a much bigger house edge than people expect, so read the odds before the first bet. ◆ Safe design shows what a tool does when it's built the other way.

A sub who says the urge to be drained has come back needs a break. Selling into that moment, with a scene or a vow, is the opposite of a break. ◆

Words that sell dependence

A promo line that names your compulsion as the reason to install a tool

WHAT IT DOES, AND WHAT TO DO

Ask what the tool does, what it collects and how you stop it.

A caption that treats an emptying balance as the point of the game

WHAT IT DOES, AND WHAT TO DO

Persona voice with a real effect on the most vulnerable readers. Close the page and set a limit before you come back.

A comparison that likens a new spend to a habit you already have

WHAT IT DOES, AND WHAT TO DO

It makes a new spend feel smaller. Decide the amount before you press anything.

An offer to help you quit, made by the person your spending pays

WHAT IT DOES, AND WHAT TO DO

She has a conflict of interest. Real help comes from someone your spending doesn't pay. See Where to get help.

PART 04

Between doms, and on makers

Pressure also runs between doms, and between doms and the people who build for them.

Between doms and on makers

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

01 *A story about your sub: "he isn't really yours"*

THE COUNTER

A sub is a person who makes his own choices. Ask him, and ask the dom concerned. Never act on a rumour alone. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

02 *An offer to help with a sub who spends heavily, and later the split has changed without you*

THE COUNTER

Don't share a heavy spender between doms: that's a red flag. Pause the money, point him to a limit and outside help, and agree any other arrangement in numbers and in writing before it starts. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

03 *A mentor's trump card: "after all I did for you", "then I'm leaving"*

THE COUNTER

Keep business apart from emotional debt. Ask for the reasoning, and refuse arrangements where seniority replaces an explanation. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

04 *Praise and pet names in exchange for unlimited free work*

THE COUNTER

Agree on scope and payment first, and keep the right to refuse. Otherwise it's free labour dressed up as devotion. ◆

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

05 *"A builder must test his own tool with real money."*

THE COUNTER

A small amount, a test account or a screen recording. Never an open-ended spend to prove it works. ◆

TRY IT

A senior dom offers help

A sub tells you he's spending heavily. A senior dom offers to help and suggests the two of you share him, with a split of what he sends.

A Decline the share, pause the money part, and point him to a limit, a break and outside help

The right answer. A heavy spender isn't an asset to divide. Both doms would be paid by his spending, so neither can be his safety net, and splitting a sub like that between doms is a red flag.

B Ask for the roles, the split and who talks to him, in writing, then go ahead

Not this one. Writing it down makes the share tidy and no safer. He's still a person who spends heavily, and you both still earn from it.

C Accept the help and sort out the split later

Not this one. Help can drift into sharing the sub without any agreement, and the money keeps flowing while nobody looks after him.

D Message the sub to say she's poaching

Not this one. It puts him in the middle of a fight, and it may turn out to be unfair to her. Talk to her first.

PART 05

Pressure from the sub side

Subs pressure doms too. Press reports that submissives also try to scam dominatrices. ◆ Their moves are simpler: haggling, "just this once", a false claim to belong to another dom, a technical excuse right when more is asked,

and vanishing after the first send. A dom who's written her rules down can point to them instead of arguing. ◆

Whatever a sub says about money, the dom doesn't get to decide whether it's true. Any claim that money is short pauses the money part of the evening. ◆

MYTH ~~Most subs who say they're broke are lying, so there's room to ask for more.~~	☆ FACT Nobody can tell from outside, and the cost of being wrong falls on the sub. ◆
MYTH ~~If I don't take everything from an unstable sub, someone else will.~~	☆ FACT That's the excuse exploitation always uses. It puts the blame for the harm on the person who gets hurt. ◆

V

VIVIAN'S FIELD NOTES

Pressure runs both ways, but not equally. I get paid when he sends, and I design the tools he uses. More of the responsibility sits with me, so my rules have to be written down before the first session and kept even when it's inconvenient.

◆

Write your rules down

1. Before the first session, say what you don't do: haggling, free previews, bargains.
2. Say plainly, ahead of time, when a sub mustn't send, and that you'll stop the session and refuse the send if he does.
3. When a rule gets tested, point to it. Don't argue.
4. When a sub says money is short, pause the money part of the evening.
5. When a sub is caught lying about another dom, block him instead of spending energy on it. A firm no ends it, and stop messaging when someone asks you to.

PART 06

Saying no

Refuse once, calmly

1. Say the boundary once, in one sentence.
2. Don't explain, justify or prove it.
3. Wait before answering anything that comes with a deadline.
4. If the pressure keeps going after the no, that's your answer. Leave, block, keep the messages and tell one person you trust.

TRY IT

Name the lever

QUESTION 1 OF 3

A dom thanks you for a send in a lukewarm way and hints that you can obviously afford more. What is it?

- ◯ Information about what you can afford
- ◯ A sales line to push the amount up
- ◯ A fair review of your send

Answer. A sales line to push the amount up. The line praises and shames you in one breath. Set the amount before the evening.

QUESTION 2 OF 3

A dom says she respects your limits, then asks for a small test just past them. What do you do?

- ◯ Treat the limit as softer now
- ◯ Take the respect and ignore the next sentence
- ◯ Explain the limit again at length

Answer. Take the respect and ignore the next sentence. Words about limits don't mean the nudge has stopped.

QUESTION 3 OF 3

A dom gives permission but says she'll just be sad. What's the cost?

- ◯ A permission that comes with guilt attached
- ◯ None, because she said yes
- ◯ A reward for honesty

Answer. A permission that comes with guilt attached. Ask for a plain yes or no, and talk about the need underneath.

PART 07

When the spending stops being a game

Some signs say a sub is deep in compulsion: spending hundreds in one day, paying several doms at once, weeks of chatting without calming down, deleting chats after each send. ◆ Hiding the spending from a partner is a risk factor, and one author compares some cases to problem gambling. ◆ Compulsion needs slower handling and no extra asks. ◆

A dom who earns from a sub can't be his safety net. She can stop, listen, ask for nothing more and point him outward. Tapering his spending herself or moving him to a better dom is a conflict of interest, and it doesn't help him. ◆ In a crisis, the help is outside: emergency services, a helpline, a person who's physically nearby. Go to The spiral, Breaks that hold, When a sub is in trouble and Where to get help.

REMEMBER IT

- Pressure takes away time, choice or privacy. Once you can name the move, it works less well on you.
- Nothing is owed unless you agreed to it in advance.
- Words about respect don’t mean the nudge has stopped.
- A design can pressure you with no person behind it: look for hidden totals, streaks and no way to stop.
- Subs pressure doms too, and written rules answer it. The dom carries more of the responsibility.
- When the spending stops being a game, help comes from someone it doesn’t pay.

SOURCES AND EVIDENCE

Check it

Every claim with its evidence level and its sources.

EVIDENCE LEVELS

◆	Checked against the original source.
◆	Stated by a serious secondary source read in full.
◆	Widely said in the scene; no document proves it.
◆	First-hand experience, not a study.

◆ Plausible, not proven yet.

01 Pressure takes away time, choice or privacy.

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02 Nearly every move below does one of the three, and it works best on someone who's aroused, tired, ashamed or attached.

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03 This scene runs on those states, so here they feel normal, and that's why the same moves work so well.

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04 A former participant describes men who sold cars, took on debt and worked second jobs.

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[a former participant] has seen men left broke and hungry from 'paying women to talk to them' (https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20251123124217/https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

Accessed 3 November 2026

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06 A writer calls the threat of exposure a common punishment from financial doms.

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Diary of a Financial Dominatrix, part one (https://www.theskinny.co.uk/sexuality/deviance/diary-of-a-financial-dominatrix-part-one)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20200805021033/https://www.theskinny.co.uk/sexuality/deviance/diary-of-a-financial-dominatrix-part-one)

Accessed 3 November 2026

07 A study notes that some findommes keep humiliation lists of clients who fail to give enough tribute.

◆

Findommes, Cybermediated Sex Work, and Rinsing (McCracken and Brooks-Gordon, Sexuality Research and Social Policy 18(4), 837-854, DOI 10.1007/s13178-021-00609-3) (https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/PMC8418458/fullTextXML)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20261016030740/https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8418458/)

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09 Real play survives the wait.

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10 There's always a third answer: reply tomorrow.

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11 You can walk away.

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12 Say it once, then stop discussing it.

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13 Words about limits don’t mean the nudge has stopped.

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14 Ask what’s wanted and slow down.

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15 A healthy bond survives a boundary.

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16 Ask for a plain yes or no, and talk about the need underneath.

◆

17 Keep the warmth that doesn’t.

◆

18 Notice it.

◆

19 See Case files.

◆

20 Wanting privacy needs no proof.

◆

21 A consensual version can be renegotiated and asks no proof of private acts.

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22 Keep your monthly limit separate from what’s in the account.

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23 Set the amount before the evening.

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24 Say no once, plainly. I’d rather lose a send than keep a sub who can’t refuse me.

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25 Each row is a pattern seen in spending tools.

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27 A rule that sounds like a small tweak can carry a much bigger house edge than people expect, so read the odds before the first bet.

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34 Press reports that submissives also try to scam dominatrices.

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Financial Domination Has a Scamming Problem (https://www.vice.com/en/article/financial-domination-has-a-scamming-problem)

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The Psychology of Financial Dominatrixes (blog post) (https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/in-excess/201612/the-psychology-financial-dominatrixes)

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44 She can stop, listen, ask for nothing more and point him outward.

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45 Tapering his spending herself or moving him to a better dom is a conflict of interest, and it doesn't help him.

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Free, confidential helplines exist in most countries.

Find a helpline →